

The Andes



THE ANDES ARE THE world's longest mountain chain, running down the entire western coast of South America. The steep slopes act as a barrier to birds, so species on the east side of the mountains differ from those on the west. Plant life in the Andes also varies dramatically over short distances, creating a variety of habitats. These range from rainforests on the lower slopes, through drier forests and grass plains higher up, to frozen wilderness near the peaks. On the upper slopes, it is so cold that some hummingbirds go into torpor at night—a kind of deep sleep where they slow down all their body processes and lower their body temperature, so they use less energy.



Andean condor
(*Vultur gryphus*)
Length: 4 ft 3 in (1 m 30 cm)
Wingspan: up to 10 ft 4 in (3 m 20 cm)

The condor probably has the greatest wingspan of any land bird.

Bare head enables the bird to reach into a carcass without getting its feathers dirty.

Andean condor

This huge vulture is the world's heaviest bird of prey, weighing up to 31 lb (14 kg). The Andean condor soars for long distances on outstretched wings, sometimes rising to heights of 23,000 ft (7,000 m) over the mountains. It has very keen eyesight and can spot dead animals to feed on from high up in the sky. It will also kill sick or wounded animals. Some Andean condors raid seabird colonies on the coast and take the eggs and chicks.

Sword-billed hummingbird
(*Ensifera ensifera*)
Length: 3 in (7.5 cm)
Length of bill: 4 in (10.5 cm)



Long bill for reaching pollen inside fuchsias and other trumpet-shaped flowers.

Sword-billed hummingbird

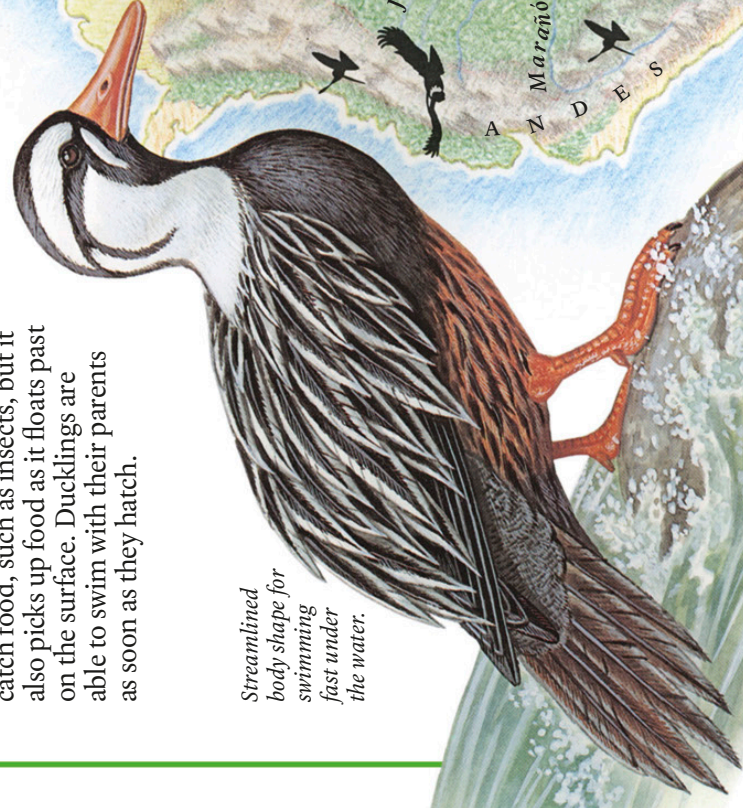
This bird's extraordinary bill enables it to reach nectar and insects deep inside trumpet-shaped flowers. As the hummingbird hovers below the flowers to feed, pollen is caught on its feathers and the bird then carries this to other flowers, pollinating the plants (helping them produce seeds). Over half the flowers in the high Andes are pollinated by hummingbirds instead of insects.

Torrent duck
(*Merganetta armata*)
Length: 1 ft 6 in (46 cm)

Torrent duck

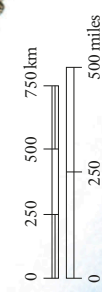
The fast-flowing rivers and streams of the Andes are home to the torrent duck. Its sharp claws and powerful legs help it cling to slippery rocks, while its stiff tail is useful for balancing and steering in the water. It dives underwater to catch food, such as insects, but it also picks up food as it floats past on the surface. Ducklings are able to swim with their parents as soon as they hatch.

Streamlined body shape for swimming fast under the water.



C A R I B B E A N S E A

S O U T H A M E R I C A



Areas of dense rainforest shrouded in mist cover the lower slopes of the Andes.

